



Star Staff Writer

George Orton

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The Quick Thumb

They have spruced up old Dudley Field in El Paso, painting it a spiffy burnt orange, renovating the press facilities and adding a crew of ball girls in hot pants, all in anticipation of the opening of the El Paso Sun Dodgers, the AA affiliate of the National League team.

Unfortunately, there has been very little done to the important part of the ball park, the part between the foul lines. And that isn't the only thing that hasn't changed in El Paso.

Maybe it is the heat, the smelter smoke or the hot wind that blows almost constantly in the Texas border town, but some of the folks there are a little bit edgy. Unfortunately for Arizona, it seems as if all of the edgy ones wear blue uniforms and umpire "games between Arizona and the University of Texas-El Paso.

The gentleman who booted Arizona baseball coach Frank Sancet out of the final game of the weekend's crucial WAC series, Oscar Vaughn, displayed a trait highly polished at UTEP: the quick thumb syndrome.

Sancet had ventured out of the dugout to protest a close call at first base. The "Fox" wasn't going to make a production number out of it, just a routine protest about what he thought was a bad call.

Vaughn accused Sancet after the game of questioning his heritage with a seven-letter Anglo-Saxon word, but Sancet firmly denies he suggested any such thing, at least before Vaughn booted him.

Whatever Sancet said to Vaughn, he had to say it quick because he wasn't out there long enough to elaborate.

Following Sancet's removal from the game (actually partial removal because Sancet spent part of the time behind the first base bleachers out of Vaughn's sight and part of the time in the tunnel which led to the UA dugout) the umpire spent a good part of the afternoon eyeing the UA bench waiting for any possible comments from the players.

Then in a display of unwarranted aggression, Vaughn accosted Sancet after the game and starting yelling at the UA coach again. Sancet had walked across the field to talk to old rival and friend, UTEP coach Andy Cohen, and Vaughn, who was leaving the park saw Sancet, made a U turn and started in on his histrionics. After a few exchanges Sancet simply ignored the umpire.

TRAVEL NOTES — Arizona players insist the umpiring in UTEP was the worst they had seen all year, if not ever. As one Arizona player put it, "It is worse than at home." . . .

Thursday night in El Paso was a sleepless one for John Glenn and Henry Cubillas. Cubillas, who has a 'trick' shoulder awoke in the early hours in severe pain and unable to move his right shoulder. Evidently he had slept wrong and the shoulder had slipped out of place.

An El Paso physician was called and Cubillas was treated at 3 a.m. in the morning. The senior from Nogales is likely out for the season . . .

Dennis Haines was murder on the UTEP pitchers, hitting five home runs in three games, but what his teammates did to Haines following his second home run on Saturday could best be termed assault and battery. Haines crossed the plate after legging out an inside the park home run that bounced high off the fence 390 feet from the plate and was mobbed as he steamed across the plate by the entire team, which collapsed in a mass beside the UA dugout . . .

Haines, who had been having trouble with the bat before the UTEP series, has adopted a new batting style and credits it with his explosion . . .

Besides clubbing the Miner pitching staff numb with his bat, Haines stiffened two runners with excellent blocks at the plate. The sophomore was a linebacker his freshman year at the UA, which quickly became apparent to the UTEP runners . . .

Rudy Mendoza, who enjoyed a fine series, had the needle sharpened and ready for his coach after driving in the three runs to win the game. "Hey 33," Mendoza said, referring to Sancet by his uniform number, "try to stay in the game next time." Sancet could only smile.